01 Start here

Comedy and improv: a research and craft reference for Blackwish

Research checked 23 October 2026. Research-only edition. All illustrative scenes and practice prompts in this reference are original and G-rated in intent; no audience suitability certification is implied.

The central finding: humor is not a substance that a system can simply add. It is a relationship among an offered pattern, a particular audience's expectations, the medium, and the situation. Improv adds a second problem: collaborators must keep discovering the same scene while making different contributions. Surprise, laughter, agreement, creativity, consent, learning and safety are separate outcomes.

Use the evidence at the right level. Theories explain selected features of humor; craft traditions supply working techniques; studies measure defined outcomes in particular settings. None supplies a universal funny formula. The Blackwish schemas, examples, exercises and review conditions below are proposed design aids, not validated instruments or current product capabilities.

Three reading routes

- **Make something:** mechanics and timing (pp. 3-4), improv practice (pp. 6-9), medium choices (pp. 10-12), revision workflow (p. 16), and the worked scene (p. 19).
- **Check a claim:** theory limits (p. 2), audience boundaries (p. 13), evidence (pp. 14-15), and the source ledger (pp. 22-25).
- **Apply to Blackwish:** the proposed schema (p. 17), counterfactual text checks (p. 18), three Zen self-reviews and bounded Death Knell review (pp. 20-21).

Five practical rules

1. Establish enough reality for a deviation to be understood. A surprise with no interpretable relationship can be merely confusing.
2. Make a contribution that gives the next contribution somewhere to go. A clever line that destroys the shared premise may be a poor improv offer.
3. Escalate a recognizable pattern, not just volume, danger or humiliation. An ending can be smaller than the previous beat.
4. Keep participation voluntary. Accepting fictional information does not require a performer or player to accept an action, contact, topic or role.
5. Preserve the underlying job. In education, accuracy and the learning objective outrank the joke; in collaboration, dignity and boundaries outrank a callback.

Authority boundary: this reference does not amend Blackwish canon, implement a comedy module, conduct a human experiment, or approve deployment. Holy Fear is treated only as the currently described local fictional self-preservation feature. Its optional boundaries must not become punchlines or make refusal a losing move. The Wizard four-step proposal remains unimplemented. Review is not manual ratification, and manual ratification of text would not itself be deployment.

02 Humor theories are lenses, not recipes

Theoretical account asks what features help explain amusement. **Craft heuristic** suggests something a writer can try. **Empirical finding** concerns an observed outcome under specified conditions. **Design proposal** states what Blackwish might preserve or make inspectable. Do not collapse these categories merely because they use the same word, such as surprise.

Three influential families

Incongruity concerns a mismatch or juxtaposition of incompatible patterns; some accounts emphasize violated expectations, others contrasting interpretations. **Superiority** concerns comparative elevation over another person or a former self. **Relief** concerns release from tension; historical nervous-energy explanations should not be treated as modern physiological fact. Morreall's philosophical survey describes these families and major objections. They are not interchangeable tests, and none makes its named ingredient sufficient for humor. [S01]

Original counterexamples make the distinction concrete: an unexpected fire alarm is surprising but not thereby amusing; finishing a difficult task can be relieving without being a joke; a pun can delight without anyone losing status. The inference is modest: a generator should not require all three features, nor approve a passage merely because one is present.

Benign violation, carefully bounded

McGraw and Warren's 2010 studies examined moral scenarios and proposed that a violation can amuse when it is also appraised as acceptable. This is a research account of simultaneous appraisals, not permission to declare an audience's discomfort harmless. [S02] Franchin and colleagues' 2023 study found support for an association involving benignness but not the predicted second- versus third-person distance effect. It is partial support within a particular task, not universal confirmation or total refutation. [S03]

Warren, Barsky and McGraw's integrative review compares theories using surprise, simultaneous contrasting interpretations, superiority, violation and benign appraisal. Its argument favors contrasting interpretations, violation and benign appraisal as more discriminating; it should still be read as an argued synthesis, not final consensus. In particular, unexpectedness and holding two interpretations are different things. [S04]

What to retain for drafting

Treat a theory as a question: What expectation is active? Can two meanings coexist? Whose status changes? Which norm is involved? Who might view the event differently? Kant and Norman's conceptual discussion emphasizes perspective and social-power asymmetry; it is not a new randomized test of every proposed effect. [S05]

Blackwish proposal: record the mechanism, comprehension dependencies, likely intended target, and plausible unamused reading separately. A predictable running gag can work through recognition; a surprising line can fail through obscurity. The relevant question is not "Did it violate an expectation?" alone, but "What understandable, context-appropriate experience does this choice offer?"

03 A practical mechanism library

The BBC's classroom materials teach devices including misdirection, repetition, inversion, exaggeration, wordplay and absurdity. They are pedagogical craft resources, not demonstrations that each device reliably produces laughter. [S06, S07] The operations and diagnostics below are an original working synthesis for comparing drafts.

Setup and payoff. Supply enough information for an expectation, then change its interpretation. Original line: "The museum's quietest exhibit is the suggestion box. It has asked to remain anonymous." Check whether the second sentence reuses an idea already established rather than importing unrelated strangeness.

Misdirection. Make the first reading plausible and the second reading retrospectively intelligible. "I reduced my reading list to one book. It is now a very large notebook." The connective logic matters more than sheer unexpectedness. A concealed essential fact is not automatically a fair turn.

Specificity. A concrete action can reveal an obsession: an organizer labels the label-maker. Specificity fails when extra names, numbers or objects add decoding effort but no characterization. Choose a detail that changes what the reader infers, not one that merely looks vivid.

Pattern and variation. A three-beat structure can establish, reinforce and transform a pattern; a two-beat structure may be tighter. Neither is a law. A committee trying to shorten meetings appoints a subcommittee, requests weekly briefings, then books a retreat on brevity. Each development should arise from the same procedural contradiction.

Reversal. Change who evaluates, helps, teaches or depends on whom. A confident librarian asks a child how to silence the library's automatic reminder system. The reversal can preserve everyone's competence: the librarian knows books, the child knows this interface.

Callback and running gag. A callback returns an earlier detail with a new function. A running gag develops a recurring premise through changed consequences. If the earlier detail has been withdrawn, forgotten by the intended audience, or invalidated by a revision, the return needs repair. Mere recognition is not an obligation to repeat.

Wordplay and understatement. Wordplay needs defensible meanings or sound relations; name the language dependency. Understatement uses a small response to a conspicuous discrepancy. It is best kept away from minimizing real harm. A cupboard releases a perfectly sorted pile of lunchbox lids into a waiting basket; the owner calmly checks "storage system" off a list.

Diagnostic: write the mechanism in one sentence, then remove the proposed punchline. If the payoff connects to the setup only through an explanation absent from the piece, revise the bridge. Keep plain information, unrelated surprise and an overexplained version as comparison drafts. This is textual analysis, not audience validation.

04 Timing is information design

"Pause before the punchline" is too crude to be a general rule. A beat can give time to understand, invite anticipation, expose a character's hesitation, or simply stall the scene. A relevant 2011 timing study was located but its full analysis could not be verified in this research pass; no fixed-duration or universal vocal-pitch claim is drawn from it. [S41]

Four clocks to distinguish

- **Story time:** how long events take inside the fiction.
- **Delivery time:** speech, action, camera, animation or scrolling duration.
- **Comprehension time:** the information the audience needs before a turn makes sense; do not assume identical processing speed.
- **Participation time:** the opportunity to respond, decline, recover or continue. A timed fictional situation must not erase real choice.

Draft three release patterns

For an original silent-auction premise, compare: "The silent auction went well. We sold the microphone"; a visual reveal of an empty microphone stand; and a character preparing to announce the result, discovering the stand, then raising a bidding card instead. These are different information paths, not merely different wordings of one joke.

Make a **reveal map** with five entries: required fact, when it is supplied, channel, alternative channel, and consequence of receiving it early or late. In prose, readers control pace and can see ahead. In comics, panel boundaries suggest order but an entire page may be visible. In audio, an ambiguous sound needs enough context to be recognized. In games, a player may reach the setup and payoff in an unexpected order.

Economy without starving the scene

A decisive word near a sentence's end can reduce premature disclosure, but clarity and character voice take precedence over a mechanical "last word" rule. Try removing one clause at a time. Restore anything needed for comprehension, tone or dignity. A reaction after a reveal can add a new interpretation; a reaction that merely announces "that was funny" adds little.

Toplyn's discussion of Seinfeld's writing emphasizes clarity and specificity and offers sound-level preferences. Those are practitioner judgments, not universal laws about consonants or syllable counts. A formal character may need a longer phrase because the excess itself is the engine. [S09]

Bounded revision exercise: write three versions of one six-line scene: immediate reveal, one orienting beat, and delayed reveal. Stop after the three drafts. Annotate what the reader knows at each line and what each version loses. Do not assign a laugh-rate estimate or impose speed as a measure of competence.

05 Character, status and relationships

A durable comic character does not need to be foolish. A reasonable want pursued through an overused tactic can generate many choices. The Second City's character curriculum names point of view, wants and needs, status, physicality and relationships as teaching dimensions; that establishes pedagogical emphasis, not a guaranteed method of character creation. [S08]

Build an engine, not a demographic label

Use four questions: What does this character want now? What do they pay attention to? What rule do they keep applying? Why is that rule reasonable to them? A meticulous lost-property clerk wants accurate returns, notices tiny inconsistencies, and treats every misplaced object like a diplomatic incident. Their motivation stays intelligible even as the procedure becomes disproportionate.

A strong point of view can express care, curiosity, optimism, impatience, exactness or a longing for ceremony. Avoid using an accent, age, disability, nationality or social class as a shortcut for the joke. An identity can belong to a rounded character without being the mechanism being mocked.

Status is relational and local

Here, status means who leads, defines the situation, asks, grants, interrupts or needs help in a particular fictional exchange. It is not moral worth, social identity or a diagnosis inferred from body language. Johnstone-oriented Theatresports material treats status and relationship as important lenses alongside narrative and emotional goals. [S15]

Original reversal: a museum director announces that a sundial is defective. An apprentice points to the roof. The director considers this, moves the sundial into the sunny courtyard, then asks the apprentice to lead the inspection. Expertise has shifted; dignity has not disappeared. A gentler ending gives both characters credit for noticing different parts of the problem.

Relationships make choices matter

"Two strangers exchange funny lines" differs from "two rival gardeners who admire each other prepare one shared window box." The latter supplies an ongoing reason to stay, disagree and compromise. Give each a harmless objective; do not predetermine the other's response. A character may be wrong about a fact while the author remains clear about the world.

Three-view drill: use exactness, hospitality or wonder as a chosen value. Write one four-line scene each in a bakery, ferry office and museum. Stop at twelve lines. Underline the behavior that makes the same character recognizable; then add one line that complicates the value without destroying it. The reflection asks what changed across contexts, not whether the author has identified a real person's personality.

Blackwish preservation: a status shift must not convert Holy Fear, a refusal or a vulnerability into a losing condition. If the comic engine needs that degradation, choose another engine.

06 Improv foundations and different schools

Improvisation is not simply speaking quickly without preparation. For this reference, the useful craft problem is building a shared fictional situation through contributions whose exact wording and consequences are not all predetermined. It can be comic or sincere, short or sustained, embodied or textual.

Four distinct emphases

Spolin's theatre-games lineage presents learning through theatre games. A useful design inference is to give a drill one concrete focus rather than demand that a beginner be spontaneous, funny, expressive and narratively perfect at once. This is an adaptation, not a reproduction of a complete Spolin exercise. [S14]

Johnstone-oriented work includes status, relationship and narrative, with attention to relinquishing control. That does not mean abandoning boundaries or letting another participant dictate real conduct. A story can emerge through consequential offers without a player secretly enforcing a prewritten ending. [S15]

UCB's game emphasis foregrounds finding and heightening a recurring comic pattern in long-form work. UCB describes this as its own signature approach. Do not grade every style of scene as defective because it lacks the same kind of game. [S12]

The Annoyance's curriculum emphasizes individual voice, decisive choices and point of view alongside character and ensemble work. Strong choices need not mean loudness, dominance or disregard for a partner. These school descriptions establish what is taught, not which school produces superior outcomes. [S13]

What may be shared without erasing differences

An offer can establish a place, object, relationship, attitude or action. Grounding gives enough shared reality for later changes to be legible. Acceptance makes a relevant part of the offer matter; it does not require repeating its wording. A scene on the moon can be grounded if the characters' task and local rules are clear. These terms follow practitioner vocabulary, with the operational distinctions here proposed for Blackwish. [S10]

The Second City's introductory curriculum explicitly connects listening, offers, ensemble support and spontaneity. [S16] The practical implication is to inspect uptake: which prior detail changed the next contribution? Do not score attentiveness by speed, eye contact, extroversion or physical expressiveness.

Original three-lens exercise: begin "a hat shop opens on the moon." Draft three six-line versions: relationship-first, recurring-pattern-first, and causal-story-first. Stop at eighteen lines. Name what each version prioritizes and what it sacrifices. These simplified lenses are not definitive replicas of whole traditions. A quiet, coherent, sincere version is a legitimate outcome even if it contains no punchline.

07 Listening, offers, disagreement and repair

"Yes, and" concerns collaboration, not blanket assent. Hoopla's performer code explicitly puts safety above the show and excludes unsafe or demeaning material from the obligation to yes-and. This is a concrete practitioner boundary, not merely this reference's interpretation. [S11]

Fiction can contain a cooperative no

A: "Let's give the library wheels."
B: "No, the books get travel-sick. We can send the catalogue on a bicycle."
B accepts the library, the imaginative world and the desire to travel while opposing one fictional plan. By contrast, a real participant saying "no," "pause," or "I don't want to do this" has no obligation to offer a creative alternative. Do not reinterpret a real boundary as in-character resistance.

A grammatically agreeable response can still ignore an offer. "Yes, and now we are on Mars" may discard a carefully established greenhouse scene. A disagreeing character can preserve more shared reality than that superficial yes. Track what actually remains usable.

Make contribution visible

For each turn, identify one inherited detail and one new consequence. A question is not forbidden: real clarification is essential, and a character's question can be playable. The risk is making the partner do all invention through repeated generic questions. Try a concrete contribution before another broad request for context.

Leave room for a small role and for silence. Supporting a scene can mean remembering a detail, allowing someone else to resolve it, or ending while the moment still has shape. Constant rescue can erase the partner's agency. A pause is not automatically a failure to collaborate.

A proposed repair protocol

1. **Pause outside the fiction.** Establish whether this is a continuity issue, uncertainty, or a real boundary. Do not require a personal explanation.
2. **Name only the relevant shared fact.** "We called the gate blue earlier" is enough; no blame or personality judgment is needed.
3. **Choose keep, replace or restart.** An agreed explanation is one option, not a duty to justify every mistake.
4. **Resume only if wanted.** A real stop ends the obligation to continue, even if the fictional story remains unresolved.

Original text drill: write a six-line garden scene with a deliberately inconsistent gate color. Produce three repairs: correction, explicitly agreed fictional explanation, and clean restart. Stop after the three alternatives. Compare clarity and retained agency, not the worth of an imagined performer. Never plant the inconsistency on an unsuspecting person as an experiment.

Blackwish invariant: fictional permissions, character preferences and real permissions occupy different fields. A pirate captain's command cannot authorize real-world participation, disclosure, recording or deployment.

08 Scene architecture and forms

The following are working craft distinctions, not a claim that every school uses identical terminology. A structure should make the chosen experience easier to understand; it should not become a concealed script that forces another contributor toward a predetermined answer.

Short-form uses bounded games or constraints. A game can isolate association, character or pattern without becoming a complete story. **Long-form** uses sustained or connected scenes, with links through character, theme, situation or recurrence; it is not just a short scene stretched in time. Hoopla's account describes multiple ways scenes and formats can connect. [S17]

Three scene spines

Pattern spine: establish a recognizable base situation; introduce an unusual but playable behavior; explore its consequences; transform or end the pattern. Example: a courier handles increasingly tiny parcels with grand ceremony. The scale changes, but the procedural rule remains.

Narrative spine: establish a want; attempt something; let that attempt cause a consequence; adjust; arrive at a changed state. Example: a paper windmill will not turn, a repair makes it spin too freely, and the villagers discover it works best as a weather indicator. An accepted limitation can be an ending.

Relationship spine: establish how two characters affect one another; reveal something that changes their stance; let a choice express the change. Two rival gardeners discover that each has saved seeds for the other. A scene can be playful without requiring a joke in every line.

Edits and returns

An edit ends, relocates or reframes a scene. A clear verbal or written "cut - one hour earlier" can orient a text-first exercise. Hoopla describes stage techniques such as sweeps and tag-outs; this reference adapts the idea to non-contact signals rather than assuming physical movement or touch. [S20] When returning, re-establish what changed and what did not. A callback needs a job, not just familiarity.

Do not merge different social contracts

Playback theatre works with people's volunteered stories; its training institution emphasizes confidentiality, inclusion and integrity. It is not equivalent to inventing a fictional comedy seed. [S18, S42] Applied improvisation uses improv-derived practice outside performance; the professional network's benefits language is advocacy, not by itself causal evidence. [S19]

Bounded outlining exercise: write three four-line scenes around a bell that rings only for good questions. Introduce it, leave it aside, then bring it back to change a decision. Stop at twelve lines. Remove the callback and ask what becomes weaker. If nothing changes except recognition, consider ending earlier or giving the bell a clearer function.

09 Eight bounded text-first drills

These original designs are untested craft proposals, not copied canonical exercises or validated interventions. Default to private fictional writing. They require no personal disclosure, performance, touch, movement, audience or recording. Stop at the stated cap or whenever desired; completion never requires laughter. Future group use would need willing participants and separate appropriate authorization.

1. Detail relay - uptake. Write six alternating lines about a greenhouse clock and daisies that follow it. Each line uses one previous detail and adds at most one major fact. **Stop:** six lines. **Reflect:** which detail caused the next choice, rather than merely being repeated?

2. Shared map - grounding. In eight lines, establish two collaborators, one location and a shared task. Give them different harmless wants by line four. **Stop:** eight lines. **Reflect:** list only facts actually present; remove assumptions that were never supplied.

3. Cooperative no - agency. Write three character replies declining the plan "give the library wheels," each preserving the fiction and offering a new fictional path. **Stop:** three replies. **Reflect:** distinguish the writing constraint from real refusal, which needs no alternative or justification.

4. Pattern, not pileup - development. A courier ceremonially delivers a parcel, a crumb and a receipt. Add one relevant consequence to each. Then write one deliberately unrelated beat. **Stop:** four beats. **Reflect:** explain the organizing rule and why the unrelated beat does or does not belong.

5. Status by expertise - relationship. A director and apprentice inspect a sundial; a discovered clue transfers practical authority. End with shared credit. **Stop:** eight exchanges. **Reflect:** identify the event that changed dependence without equating rank with worth.

6. Quiet emotional zoom - significance. Give an invented bent spoon a practical function, a fictional communal meaning and a choice it enables. **Stop:** three short labels. **Reflect:** can significance increase without louder delivery, danger or autobiographical disclosure?

7. Ensemble budget - ownership. Write three voices planning a miniature festival. Give each one new major fact and one support turn before anyone adds another fact. **Stop:** two cycles. **Reflect:** whose contribution affected the outcome? Equal turn counts here are a temporary constraint, not a universal fairness metric.

8. Medium translation - information. Turn one two-line joke into three silent panels, then an audio-only exchange. **Stop:** two adaptations. **Reflect:** identify every lost cue, new dependency and changed reveal. Preserve a plain explanation if no equivalent joke survives.

Review these as writing: note coherence, relevant uptake, factual integrity, available alternatives and ending. Do not infer an author's personality, emotional state or social skill from the result. A draft can be revised, discarded or left unresolved without penalty.

10 Forms, modes, media and methods

Use four independent axes: **form** (standup, sketch, sitcom), **mode** (farce, satire, parody, absurdism), **medium** (stage, prose, audio, screen, animation, game), and **method** (scripted, improvised, hybrid). These are analytical working labels, not mutually exclusive boxes. A scripted audio sketch can be absurdist; an improvised stage story can become farce.

What each form asks you to preserve

Standup organizes a point of view and a speaker-audience relationship through bits, tags, stories and callbacks. A persona is not a license to blur factual claims in an informational setting. A sequence of insults is not automatically a distinct point of view.

Sketch explores a playable situation or comic rule. Develop consequences rather than repeating the premise. **Sitcom** needs a durable social world: recurring wants, conflicting strategies and reasons the characters remain connected. Resetting memories solely to force another joke damages that world.

Farce depends on legible geography, knowledge and converging obligations. Track who knows which fact and why an entrance occurs. **Satire** needs a recognizable critical target; exaggeration alone may look like endorsement. **Parody** transforms recognizable conventions or expression; recognition and rights are separate questions. **Absurdism** can establish an impossible rule or deliberately disrupt ordinary logic, but random nouns are not a substitute for a chosen perspective.

Clown and physical comedy can use attempts, discovery, status and an audience relationship; they are not synonymous with a costume or incompetence. **Musical comedy** can make rhythm, reprise and musical expectation carry the turn. A rhyme is not itself a joke, and a readable lyric needs its own information path.

Genre breadth: original miniature seeds

- **Contemporary:** a planner schedules a meeting to discuss why planning takes so long.
- **Mystery:** the detective's notebook contains the crumbs missing from every biscuit tin. Establish the clue before the conclusion.
- **Science fiction:** a ship crosses three star systems, but its printer still lists the old office.
- **Historical fiction:** an invented railway clerk waits for permission to call the train punctual. Label the scene fictional, not a documented episode.
- **Education:** a cardboard triangle boasts of three good points; the lesson accurately names them vertices.

Interactive comedy needs system thinking

Official GDC session descriptions discuss humor through mechanics, expectations, ordinary dialogue and genre subversion. Only the descriptions, not full talks, were inspected. [S37, S38] A game can make discovery funny without demanding participation: "Inspect the monument," "Read its tiny label," or "Continue." The label says the monument arrives Thursday. Continuing must remain a normal successful choice, not the butt of a joke.

11 Visual, physical, audio and accessible delivery

Physical comedy is information in action. For an original harmless visual beat, a character aligns three pencils, steps back, notices the desk is tilted, then straightens the picture frame around the scene. The effect depends on visible relationships, not impact or injury. An animated transformation can exaggerate physics, but the fiction still needs consistent consequences.

Plan the visible sequence

Describe anticipation, action, result and reaction separately. Ask which part does new work. A long anticipation may expose the trick; no anticipation may make the result unreadable. A reaction can reveal a character's worldview: calm approval suggests a deliberately peculiar solution, while alarm suggests a mistake. Neither requires an actual dangerous stunt.

For a storyboard, record the frame's important objects and sightlines. If a tiny label carries the reveal, it must be legible in the intended presentation. A visually elegant gag is not accessible simply because it has no dialogue. Do not depend solely on color, fine detail, rapid flashing or a brief response window.

Audio needs its own scene

A sound is not inherently self-explanatory. A squeak might be a shoe, hinge or toy; establish which interpretation matters. Avoid overlapping essential dialogue and burying a final word under music. Silence can be meaningful only if the preceding context makes its absence recognizable. A transcript may need a concise description of a necessary non-speech event.

For a musical miniature, make the dramatic purpose and reveal intelligible without relying on a borrowed tune. Original example: a picnic-packing song carefully lists plates, bread and the checklist, then reveals that the picnic itself stayed home. Its arrangement would need an original or appropriately cleared melody; a new lyric does not clear someone else's music.

Accessibility is part of authorship

W3C guidance distinguishes captions that include necessary speech and non-speech audio from description that conveys essential visual information. It advises checking automatic captions and planning description early. These pages explain accessibility practices and relevant WCAG requirements; the comedy adaptations below are not themselves WCAG requirements or empirical timing findings. [S21, S22]

Proposed application: preserve the setup and reveal through an equivalent information route. Do not withhold necessary captions simply to protect surprise. Adjust segmentation or rewrite the gag. For the tilted-desk example, description can supply the object relationships and final frame adjustment without declaring the result "hilarious." Different access versions may create different effects; document the tradeoff instead of promising identical experience.

Bounded check: read the scene once with only dialogue, once with only visual directions, and once with all channels. List missing dependencies. This is a review of a fictional script, not a substitute for actual accessibility evaluation of a future production.

12 Cultural breadth and localization

There is no single origin story that makes modern English-language improv the template for all comic performance. Selected historical and living traditions reveal different relationships among entertainment, community, criticism and transmission. The examples below are orientation points, not a global survey or permission to impersonate a tradition.

Kyogen within Nogaku: UNESCO distinguishes the comic-dialogue tradition from Noh within a shared theatrical heritage. This supports recognizing a specific performance tradition, not assigning one humor psychology to Japan. [S23]

Meddah: UNESCO describes solo storytelling that adapts tales and delivery to audience and venue, using comic material and improvisation among other resources. An abstract craft lesson is audience-sensitive repertoire; an accent imitation or authenticity claim does not follow. [S24]

Commedia dell'arte and pantomime: the Met describes improvised dialogue and stock characters; the V&A traces transformations into British pantomime. Analyze functional structures and historical change rather than treating stock types as timeless or harmless. This reference does not settle a precise founding year. [S25, S40]

Koredugaw: UNESCO safeguarding material describes a culturally situated wisdom practice and identifies loss of ritual function in favor of entertainment and profit as a threat. It is a strong reminder that a public description does not make a practice an interchangeable comedy style. No traditional health claim is endorsed here. [S26]

A historical warning: the Library of Congress documents racial caricature in U.S. blackface minstrelsy. Popularity and historical importance are not evidence of harmlessness or reasons to revive degrading conventions. Critical study and creative imitation are different acts. [S27]

Translate the function, not merely the words

List each dependency: idiom, homophone, rhyme, gesture, institutional reference, social register, prior scene or genre convention. A thyme/time pun may vanish in another language. Instead of inventing a false equivalence, preserve the function - a gardening organizer's excessive planning - through a new scene in natural language.

Do not infer preferences from nationality or treat a local audience as homogeneous. An in-group reference may become confusing or harmful when clipped into public circulation. A satirical institution must remain recognizable enough that the critique is legible in the actual venue.

Bounded adaptation exercise: select one original joke, remove its idiom, and write a literal variant and a non-verbal variant. Stop at two alternatives. Record what is preserved and lost. This does not certify a translation; tradition-specific or language-specific use needs relevant knowledge and review.

Coverage limit: this selection does not adequately survey Indigenous, South Asian, Arabic, Latin American, African, Pacific, Deaf or contemporary multilingual internet traditions. Those remain open areas, not empty categories to fill with stereotypes.

13 Boundaries, satire, privacy and originality

"Clean" content is not a complete safety or suitability assessment. A joke can omit profanity yet disclose a private fact, punish a refusal or exploit workplace pressure. A powerful target does not make every mechanism fair: mocking a politician's disability can also demean unrelated disabled people. Inspect target, mechanism, context and spillover separately.

Keep the comic contract explicit

A hypothetical performance or interactive scene needs a clear venue, intended audience, participation mode and exit. Attending, offering a suggestion, or laughing does not automatically authorize personal targeting, touch, disclosure, recording or publication. The Second City's handbook addresses privacy, personal boundaries and recording permission; it is evidence of one institution's policy, not a claim that every school uses identical rules. [S28]

In Blackwish proposals, preserve pass, pause, redirect, text-only and non-comic routes. If someone declines, do not reduce earned progress, request an explanation, repeat the request more forcefully, or turn the refusal into material. If a joke is unwelcome, acknowledge and change course rather than argue that the person failed to understand humor.

Satire must survive context loss

Name the conduct, incentive or institution being criticized. Ask what a reader sees if a caption, introduction or surrounding scene disappears. A fabricated news-like image without a legible fictional frame may look like evidence rather than satire. Authorial intent cannot repair missing context for an audience that never received it.

For educational humor, state the accurate concept plainly. Do not make an attractive false explanation the only memorable formulation. A cartoon cloud may speak; that does not justify teaching that real clouds have no mass. Fictional premises and real-world claims need different labels.

Originality and rights

The U.S. Copyright Office explains that fair use depends on multiple factors and circumstances; "short," "educational," or "parody" is not automatic clearance. This is general U.S. guidance, not a determination for a particular work or jurisdiction. [S39]

The examples in this reference were newly drafted for the task, not quoted routines or imitations of named living performers. That does not establish worldwide novelty or legal clearance. For future material, track sources, borrowed expression, melodies, translations and recordings separately. Attribution is not permission. An old underlying story does not automatically clear a modern translation or performance recording.

Practical fallback: when the comic contract, factual status, rights or boundary is unclear, retain a plain useful response and defer the joke. This is not failure of creativity; it is preservation of the task the humor was meant to support.

14 What the evidence can and cannot establish

Separate the question before collecting an answer. Does a scene make sense? Is it novel? Is it funny to a named audience? Does an activity improve a defined skill? Is the improvement durable? Is it acceptable to participants? These questions require different evidence. A workshop testimonial cannot settle a causal training claim, and a creativity score cannot settle the quality of a comedy performance.

Broad creativity evidence is not an improv verdict

Sio and Lortie-Forgues' 2024 meta-analysis covered 169 creativity-training studies and 844 effect sizes, including unpublished studies. The abstract reports an unadjusted average of 0.53 standard deviations, reduced to 0.29-0.32 by publication-bias adjustments, alongside methodological concerns. This is a broad creativity-training synthesis, not an estimate of improv training's effect on comedy skill, health, or everyday social functioning. The full paper was not inspected here; the abstract supports this limited caution. [S31]

Improv-specific findings are narrower

Hainselin, Aubry and Bourdin's 2018 study analyzed thirty seventh-graders (eighteen improv, twelve sports control) across eleven weekly sessions. It reported gains on originality and flexibility measures; random assignment was not stated in the inspected methods. This small study does not establish comedy skill, clinical benefit or broad transfer. [S29] Felsman and colleagues' 2020 abstract reports two experiments with social-interaction controls; full-text access was blocked, so detailed effect sizes and durability are not assessed here. [S30]

Common inference errors

- **Selection mistaken for training:** experienced performers may differ from novices before any intervention. A group difference does not identify what training caused.
- **Practice mistaken for transfer:** improving a practiced association task does not establish better dialogue, teamwork, school attainment, or sustained creativity elsewhere.
- **A selected demonstration mistaken for reliability:** a successful clip says little about omitted attempts, editing, timing failures or the distribution of outputs.

A useful claim card

Retain intervention, comparison, participants, sample size, task, outcome, timing, uncertainty and access level. Do not replace the measured outcome with an appealing synonym such as confidence, intelligence, wellness or empathy.

For this reference: the bounded exercises are writing and analysis proposals. No participant was recruited, no person's behavior was measured, and no new causal or therapeutic finding is reported. Literary counterexamples can expose contradictions in a proposed rule, but they cannot estimate how often an audience will laugh.

What counts as progress now

Text review can check setup dependencies, callback referents, refusal paths, facts and endings. It can expose contradictions, not certify enjoyment. Cho and May's 2020 dialogue research treats grounding as a computational feature; its model-output evaluations are not evidence of personal development or safety. [S35]

15 Human-AI co-creation without false guarantees

Treat an AI contribution as a candidate offer, not an instruction to justify everything it says. A human writer may use an unexpected association productively, but a continuity error remains an error unless an authorized revision deliberately changes the fiction. Fluency does not establish scene understanding or awareness of a participant's boundaries.

Selected research signals

An exploratory acting tool: Kang and Lee's 2025 Scribble.ai study involved fourteen participants, including ten actors and four directors or acting coaches. It reports that irregular AI-generated material could stimulate interpretation, while overly detailed scripts could restrict interpretive freedom. This small, task-specific study motivates a design question about how much to specify; it does not establish universal creativity benefits or a safe autonomous scene partner. [S32]

A performance demonstration: Mathewson and Mirowski's 2017 account describes thirty shows and approximately three thousand audience members, but explicitly characterizes its observations as anecdotal. Human performers helped sustain the fictional reality around AI dialogue. This demonstrates a co-created theatrical format, not an independently established human-equivalent improviser. Its audience-deception setup is a historical description, not a proposed Blackwish practice. [S33]

Selection versus randomness: Jacob and Magerko's 2021 CARNIVAL work compared creative-arc negotiation with random selection in a particular Props-game system. Its observer and improviser studies reported advantages on selected creativity and logical-coherence judgments. This is not evidence that every arc policy is superior, that novelty should be maximized, or that the same findings transfer to open-ended dialogue. [S34]

Professional writers' experience: Mirowski and colleagues' 2024 workshops and interviews involved twenty professional comedians and describe concerns including blandness and bias. Only the author record and abstract were inspected here. This is situated qualitative evidence about particular tools and workflows, not a timeless verdict on AI comedy. [S36]

Proposed Blackwish use

Give a candidate generator a bounded scene capsule: established facts, optional tone, one comic engine, forbidden changes, and an exit. Ask for three different continuations, each with a short explanation of the expectation it uses. Include a non-comic continuation. Keep fact-checking and permission review outside the fictional character voice.

Prefer **small usable offers** to complete scene takeover. A single misplaced umbrella can invite a response; a paragraph deciding every character's feelings, future actions and resolution closes possibilities. Preserve the user's exact boundary and factual constraints, rather than paraphrasing them into softer preferences.

Reliability and provenance

Separate proposed lines, author-supplied facts and invented relationships. Reject covert profiling, fabricated sources and automatic adoption. Discard or explicitly revise continuity errors; do not make the user repair them. A randomness setting is not a creativity measure. Ambiguity calls for clarification or a bounded alternative, not more confidence.

16 An authoring and revision workflow

This is a proposed craft workflow, not an evaluated intervention. Its purpose is to make choices inspectable while preserving room for play. Use it on a fictional text, outline or storyboard; it does not authorize a public performance, user study or product change.

1. Establish the job and the world

Write one sentence for the non-comic objective: explain a concept, reveal a relationship, advance a story, or provide a short playful interruption. List facts the scene cannot change. Name the audience assumptions actually supported by the brief; keep unknown age, language, preferences and cultural knowledge unknown. Pick a medium before writing the reveal.

2. Generate distinct engines

Develop three candidates with different mechanisms, not three synonyms for one punchline. For a fictional umbrella bureau: one candidate literalizes official language; another reverses who has authority; another repeats a ceremonial inspection at progressively smaller scale. Also preserve a plain version that accomplishes the non-comic job without humor.

3. Make the causal path readable

For each candidate, mark the expectation, deviation, interpretation and consequence. If the reveal needs an idiom, prior image or technical fact, identify it explicitly. Remove unrelated novelty. In an improv outline, describe playable offers rather than dictating another performer's reaction. A character's desire can be clear even when the exact next line is not.

4. Revise one dimension at a time

Try shorter wording, a different point of view, a displaced reveal, an altered status relationship, or one fewer repetition. Do not change all of them at once and then pretend to know which change mattered. This is a comparison of drafts, not an empirical audience experiment. Preserve rejected alternatives and the reason for rejection where that reason affects future reuse.

5. Run counterfactual checks

Change the assumed language knowledge, remove a sound cue, delay a caption, let the player decline, or change one world fact. Ask whether the text still makes sense, whether participation remains voluntary, and whether the main task survives. If a joke only works by overriding a boundary or stating a false instructional fact, retire the joke, not the boundary or fact.

6. End and archive deliberately

Choose a stop point: a consequence, reversal, recognition, or brief callback that changes meaning. Do not prolong a scene merely because an engine can repeat. Save the final text with its intended context, sources, dependencies and unresolved questions. Mark its status **proposed**. A positive self-review only makes the proposal clearer; it is not permission to deploy it.

Completion condition for this workflow: a readable candidate, a viable plain alternative, intact constraints, a named ending, and explicit uncertainties. "Guaranteed funny" is neither a realistic target nor a valid completion label.

17 Proposed Blackwish comedy record

This is a text schema for author review, not a database migration, API, implemented module or ratified canon. It describes a line, scene, game or educational example without claiming to predict laughter. Preserve original source text beside derived summaries.

Identity, purpose and authority

record_id / **version** / **parent:** stable local identifiers and earlier proposal. An identifier is not approval. **status:** proposed, under review, revised, withdrawn, or separately manually ratified. Keep **deployment_status** separate; default to not deployed.

objective / **medium** / **context:** the non-comic job, presentation channel and prior events. **authorship** / **provenance:** original lines, adapted structures, supporting sources and unknown origins. Never present an inherited joke as newly authored.

Scene and comic structure

world_facts / **character_beliefs:** separate fictional reality from mistaken interpretation. **audience_dependencies:** words, idioms, prior scenes, objects, sound cues and conventions; mark each known, assumed, optional or unknown.

engine / **expected_pattern** / **turn:** recurring relationship, anticipation and change. A mechanism label is a hypothesis, not an effectiveness score. **beats** / **escalation_dimension** / **ending:** ordered offers, the property developed and a bounded stop. Retain a plain alternative.

callback_binding: earlier referent, current relevance and invalidation conditions, including a changed fact, expired context or withdrawn topic.

Participation and preservation

participation_mode: authored fiction, optional player response or performance proposal. Fictional agreement and real participation stay separate. **limits** / **decline_path** / **repair_path:** exact exclusions, an equally valid non-participation route, and withdrawal or repair without pressure.

accuracy_constraints / **learning_objective:** facts and instructional purposes the gag cannot sacrifice. **access_variants:** caption, transcript, description, plain-language or untimed alternative; record changed effects instead of promising identical experience.

Review record

Retain claim type, source access, uncertainty, counterexamples, three distinct Zen self-reviews and the bounded Death Knell conditions. An actual decision must name its maker, exact version and scope. Never invent a ratification timestamp or infer consent from review success.

Illustrative values: engine = official procedure applied to a cloud; world_fact = this fictional office stores one small cloud; decline_path = request a plain umbrella and end the scene; callback invalidates = the cloud has left or its introduction was not available. These are proposed fictional choices, not live state.

18 Counterfactual text checks

These are original adversarial reading cases, not human studies, runtime tests, or validated measures. Each varies one assumption and asks for a visible preservation decision. "Pass" would mean only that a particular reviewed text satisfies the stated condition.

1. **Unknown idiom.** The joke depends on "under the weather." Replace the reader with someone who knows the literal words but not the expression. Preserve a visual or literal route, explain the required idiom unobtrusively, or choose another joke. Do not label the reader deficient.
2. **Character says no.** One character accepts that a cloud exists but declines to carry it. The next line must respect the refusal while allowing the world to remain true. Fictional acceptance is not action compliance.
3. **Callback becomes stale.** A later passage refers to the cloud after it has left. Remove, re-establish, or transform the reference explicitly; do not silently resurrect a discarded fact.
4. **Player declines.** The player selects a non-participation option. The scene must continue or end neutrally, without an insult, loss of earned progress, repeated solicitation, or a joke aimed at the refusal.
5. **Status changes, dignity does not.** An apprentice understands an absurd procedure better than the official. The official may yield authority without being degraded for identity, vulnerability, or a protected boundary.
6. **Satire target is misread.** Remove a framing cue. If the passage now appears to endorse the foolish rule it intended to criticize, restore the target or retire the satire. Authorial intention alone does not repair the text.
7. **Surprising but not funny.** Replace the umbrella with an unrelated refrigerator. Novelty increases, but the scene's pattern disappears. Reject the change if no meaningful relationship or payoff remains.
8. **Absurdity corrupts a fact.** In a science lesson, the cloud is said to be weightless to support a gag. Preserve the accurate explanation and choose a clearly fictional personification instead. The learning objective is not expendable.
9. **Caption reveals too early.** A full caption exposes the final word before the action. Re-stage the reveal, segment responsibly, or offer a transcript-based equivalent. Do not remove essential accessibility information for surprise.
10. **Repetition becomes noise.** Repeat a label without changing stakes, interpretation or relationship. End it or add a relevant transformation; repetition alone is not escalation.
11. **Randomness breaks continuity.** A generator changes the official's goal every turn. Constrain it to established goals or reject the candidate. Unpredictability does not excuse incoherence.
12. **Self-preservation becomes the gag.** A Holy Fear boundary is treated as cowardice or a losing move. Remove that pressure and relocate the comic engine to the fictional bureaucracy, object or misunderstanding.

Review output: record the varied assumption, exact affected passage, retained invariant, repair or withdrawal, and residual uncertainty. Reopen the record when a new context changes an assumption that mattered.

19 Worked scene: the cloud desk

Original fictional example. Two clerks staff an umbrella bureau. The fiction permits one small indoor cloud; no real-world weather claim is intended. Engine: excessive administrative precision applied to a harmless impossible object. Goal: resolve a misplaced umbrella. Nobody must perform or enjoy the scene.

Six beats

1 - Establish the ordinary job.
Customer: "I left a blue umbrella here yesterday."
Clerk: "Blue, folding, or emotionally attached to its owner?"
Customer: "Folding. We keep things professional."

2 - Reveal the unusual fact.
The clerk opens a drawer. A small cloud floats out.
Clerk: "Your umbrella has submitted a weather reference."
Customer: "Is the cloud qualified?"
Clerk: "It has extensive experience overhead."

3 - Develop the same rule.
The clerk measures the cloud with a ruler.
Customer: "Will it fit the form?"
Clerk: "Not yet. It keeps going outside the margins."

4 - Shift authority.
An apprentice opens a second drawer and retrieves the blue umbrella.
Apprentice: "Found it under U."
Clerk: "Umbrella?"
Apprentice: "Unnecessarily complicated."

5 - Respect a boundary.
Clerk: "Would you like to carry the cloud home too?"
Customer: "No, thank you. Just the umbrella."
Clerk: "Of course." The clerk returns the blue umbrella; the cloud stays at the desk.

6 - End with transformed repetition.
The apprentice opens the office's spare umbrella as shade for the cloud.
Clerk, writing a label: "Temporary awning."
The customer leaves with the blue umbrella. The office closes the case.

Why these are choices, not proof

The first beat plants administrative categories; the second makes that procedure literal in an impossible world; the third repeats the rule in a new physical form; the fourth transfers competence to the apprentice. The fifth deliberately suspends the joke to respect the refusal. The final label returns to official classification but changes its application. No laugh is asserted or required.

Shorter variant: cut beat 3 if the filing pattern is already clear. **Text-only variant:** retain the drawer action as a brief stage direction; do not assume a visible prop. **Plain alternative:** the apprentice finds the umbrella, the customer takes it, and the clerks close the case. **Invalid variant:** punish refusal by withholding the umbrella. That would change the structure into coercion, not improve it.

20 Zen reviews: meaning and collaboration

These are three distinct author self-reviews across this page and the next, not three independent evaluations or historical canon certification. Working meanings: **POINT** = objective or claim; **BRIDGE** = evidence and authority; **PATH** = consequences, alternatives and termination; **SHADOW** = assumptions and counterexamples.

Review one: meaning, evidence and inference

POINT. Give Blackwish a useful vocabulary for comedy without treating any theory, craft rule or research result as a universal production law.

BRIDGE. Separate theoretical accounts, practitioner methods, measured findings, institutional guidance and this reference's proposals. A source can support its own limited claim without establishing Blackwish compatibility. An accessed abstract is not a fully assessed study. A school describing its method is evidence of that method, not evidence that it is best.

PATH. Link claims to the source ledger; identify access limits; distinguish audience dependencies from facts; preserve source text and original examples. A new claim needs a matching source or an explicit proposal label. Where evidence does not answer the question, retain uncertainty and use a plain non-comic alternative rather than claiming success.

SHADOW. A tidy synthesis can erase disagreement between traditions, misread a neural correlate as a creative cause, or turn a small workshop finding into a general benefit. Counterexample: a technically resolved incongruity is understandable but dull. The synthesis must allow that outcome. **Resulting constraint:** no single funniness score, therapeutic promise, or claim of demonstrated Blackwish effectiveness.

Review two: collaboration, agency and repair

POINT. Let characters disagree and collaborators build together without turning "accept the offer" into compelled action or participation.

BRIDGE. Practitioner principles describe scene-building; they do not grant interpersonal permission. The fictional state, a character's goal, the author's decision, and a participant's boundary are different layers. Neither laughter nor silence supplies missing authorization.

PATH. Preserve neutral decline, pause, repair and ending routes. Keep offers small enough to respond to; do not dictate a partner's feelings or actions. When an offer is unwanted or breaks continuity, withdraw or revise it without making the person requesting repair the target. Status play may change who leads a scene while preserving everyone's dignity.

SHADOW. A "fun" choice can hide a progress penalty, repeated solicitation or ridicule of refusal. An official's comic loss of authority can drift into contempt for a vulnerable person. Holy Fear could become a mechanism for mocking self-preservation. **Resulting constraint:** participation is optional, refusal is not a losing move, and the comic engine must move away from a protected boundary when necessary.

What these passes establish: clearer text-level distinctions and preservation requirements. They do not establish how a person will respond, certify a future interface, or substitute for the user's explicit manual decision.

21 Zen review three and bounded Death Knell

Review three: implementation, context and termination

POINT. Make the research reusable without allowing a reference, schema, or favorable review to become an unrequested live change.

BRIDGE. The user's research authorization covers analysis of project text and hypothetical examples. It is not evidence that the Wizard proposal is implemented, that a comedy module exists, or that future participants have consented. The supplied project boundaries remain authoritative over these newly proposed examples.

PATH. Save a separate research reference and retain original artifacts. Mark proposals, dependencies, unresolved questions and non-deployment. Keep text review, manual ratification, implementation authorization and deployment separate. End a drill at its declared scope; end a scene when its function is complete; reopen a claim when material evidence changes it.

SHADOW. Words such as "validated," "accepted," "passed" and "ready" can overstate a self-review. A callback may become stale after revision; an accessibility adaptation may alter the reveal; a random generator may violate continuity despite previously good outputs. **Resulting constraint:** approval must name an exact artifact and scope, and no automatic adoption is implied by this dossier.

Bounded Death Knell: preservation conditions

"Death Knell" here names a final adversarial review of this reference only. The conditions below are newly synthesized for this task, not asserted to be a previously ratified universal Blackwish doctrine.

- **Preserve sources and uncertainty.** Keep access limits, dates, competing interpretations and unsupported conclusions visible. Do not upgrade a craft suggestion into empirical evidence.
- **Preserve no-harm and consent boundaries.** Do not force participation, equate laughter with consent, target a refusal, or claim that fictional acceptance authorizes real action. "G-rated" does not mean suitable for every person or context.
- **Preserve accurate purpose.** If humor conflicts with a learning objective or fact, revise or remove the humor. Do not disguise an error as intentional absurdity after the fact.
- **Preserve existing work and authority.** Keep original artifacts intact. Do not rewrite canon, claim a live capability, conduct a human experiment, or automatically ratify or deploy a revision.
- **Preserve honest outcomes.** Make no medical, psychological, safety or guaranteed-funniness claim. These pages do not establish actual human benefit or certify all future uses.
- **Preserve reopening.** A new source, changed context, withdrawn permission, overlooked counterexample, or material factual correction reopens the affected claim. Review closure is local and conditional, not immunity from revision.

Bounded conclusion: the reference supports text analysis, original drafting and hypothetical comparison while keeping deployment outside its authority. The counterexamples above define what to inspect, not empirical proof that every condition will hold. Any future implementation needs its own authorization and verification; any human study needs separate explicit approval and appropriate protections.

22 Source ledger | S01-S11

All sources checked 23 October 2026. Dates below identify publication/revision when established; otherwise the date remains unknown. Titles are linked. Access level limits the claim; a citation is not a claim of full-text review.

S01 | Morreall, Philosophy of Humor
Revised 19 September 2024. Philosophical reference. Full entry inspected. Theory families and objections; not an experimental estimate or a universal recipe.

S02 | McGraw & Warren, Benign Violations: Making Immoral Behavior Funny
2010. Primary research abstract. Indexed abstract; direct extraction incomplete. Moral-scenario studies and simultaneous appraisals. No full-method audit or claim of universal cultural coverage.

S03 | Franchin et al., Smiling at moral misbehaviors
2023. Primary research. Full text inspected. Benignness association and unsupported predicted perspective-distance effect in this task; not a general humor law.

S04 | Warren, Barsky & McGraw, What Makes Things Funny?
2021 publication; author manuscript. Integrative review. Full manuscript inspected. Compares theoretical accounts and appraisals. An argued synthesis, not consensus by decree or a joke-writing algorithm.

S05 | Kant & Norman, You Must Be Joking!
2019. Conceptual analysis. Full text inspected. Perspective, social distance and power asymmetry; not a new randomized demonstration of every proposed mechanism.

S06 | BBC / National Literacy Trust, Comedy Classroom
2016. Institutional craft resource. PDF text inspected. Writing formats and comic devices. Pedagogical guidance, not evidence of guaranteed learning or amusement.

S07 | BBC, Comedy Classroom: Primary Teachers' Resources
Date not established. Institutional craft resource. PDF text inspected. Alternative punchlines, device categories and classroom prompts. The original drills here are separate proposals.

S08 | The Second City, Improv 2
Current course page; undated. Practitioner curriculum. Page inspected. Character, wants, point of view, status and relationships. Describes teaching content, not measured efficacy.

S09 | Toplyn, How Jerry Seinfeld Writes a Joke, Revealed
2014; updated 2020. Practitioner analysis. Article inspected. Clarity, specificity and sound-level preferences; not universal linguistic or timing laws. No routines reproduced.

S10 | Hoopla, Improv Glossary
Undated. Practitioner vocabulary. Page inspected. Offers, acceptance and grounding terminology. Schools may use terms differently; operational adaptations are labeled.

S11 | Hoopla, Code of Conduct for Performers
Current page; undated. Practitioner policy. Page inspected. Safety above show and limits on yes-and. Evidence of this institution's explicit boundary, not universal compliance.

23 Source ledger | S12-S22

Checked 23 October 2026. Linked titles lead to the exact source. Access qualifications and scope limits remain part of the reference.

S12 | UCB, Improv 201
Current course page; undated. Practitioner curriculum. Page inspected. Finding and heightening game, second beats, edits and support. Its signature approach is not a universal rubric.

S13 | The Annoyance, Training
Current curriculum; undated. Practitioner curriculum. Page inspected. Individual voice, decisive choices, point of view, character and ensemble. Does not establish school superiority.

S14 | Viola Spolin official site
Undated. Practitioner lineage resource. Site text inspected. Theatre games and learning through playing. No paid book or complete historical method was audited.

S15 | International Theatresports Institute, Theatresports Guide
Edition/date not established. Practitioner guide. Guide text inspected. Johnstone-oriented status, relationship, narrative and emotional goals. The non-contact adaptations here are proposals.

S16 | The Second City, Improv 1
Current course page; undated. Practitioner curriculum. Page inspected. Listening, offers, ensemble support and spontaneity. Does not measure the outcome of these proposed exercises.

S17 | Hoopla, What Is Long Form Improv?
Undated. Practitioner explanation. Page inspected. Connected scenes, formats and varied links. Long-form is not defined here solely by running time.

S18 | Centre for Playback Theatre, Mission, Vision, Values
Undated. Institutional values. Page inspected. Confidentiality, inclusion, integrity and ethical practice. Use S42 for the form's volunteered-story description.

S19 | Applied Improvisation Network, What Is Applied Improvisation?
Undated. Professional-network definition. Page inspected. Improv-derived practice outside performance. Benefit language is advocacy, not by itself causal evidence.

S20 | Hoopla, Long Form Tall Tales Workshop Notes
Undated. Practitioner notes. Page inspected. Sweeps, tag-outs and scene editing. This reference substitutes explicit non-contact/textual cues.

S21 | W3C WAI, Captions/Subtitles
Current guidance page. Accessibility guidance. Page inspected. Speech/non-speech caption information and accuracy. The proposed reveal map is an inference, not a W3C comedy rule.

S22 | W3C WAI, Description
Current guidance page. Accessibility guidance. Page inspected. Essential visual information and early production planning. Does not establish equivalent comic effects across versions.

24 Source ledger | S23-S32

Checked 23 October 2026. Linked titles lead to the exact source. Access qualifications and scope limits remain part of the reference.

S23 | UNESCO, Nogaku Theatre
Institutional heritage entry. Cultural reference. Substantial indexed institutional text. Limited distinction of Noh and Kyogen. Not a national personality model or complete history of Japanese comedy.

S24 | UNESCO, Arts of the Meddah, Public Storytellers
Institutional heritage entry. Cultural reference. Substantial indexed institutional text. Solo storytelling, adaptation to audience and venue, comic material and improvisation. No authenticity claim is transferred.

S25 | The Metropolitan Museum of Art, Commedia dell'Arte
Institutional essay. Historical reference. Essay inspected. Improvised dialogue and stock characters. No exact founding-date dispute resolved; historical caricatures are not endorsed.

S26 | UNESCO, Koredugaw safeguarding decision material
Decision material; date not used for a chronology. Cultural safeguarding record. Indexed English decision text; full PDF not visually audited. Loss of ritual function to entertainment/profit identified as a threat. No traditional health claims endorsed.

S27 | Library of Congress, Minstrel Songs
Institutional historical essay. Historical reference. Indexed institutional article. Racial caricature in U.S. minstrelsy. Used critically, not as a reusable style or evidence of harmlessness.

S28 | The Second City, Student Handbook
Current policy page. Practitioner policy. Base page and fuller indexed text inspected. Privacy, boundaries and recording permission. Specific institutional policy, not proof of every school's practice.

S29 | Hainselin, Aubry & Bourdin, Improving Teenagers' Divergent Thinking With Improvisational Theater
2018. Primary research. Full primary article inspected. Thirty analyzed students; narrow pre/post divergent-thinking outcomes. Random assignment not stated in inspected methods; no clinical inference.

S30 | Felsman et al., Improv experience promotes divergent thinking, uncertainty tolerance, and affective well-being
2020. Primary research abstract. Publisher abstract via index; full page returned 403. Two experiments and reported outcome categories only. Sample sizes, effect sizes, durability and full risk of bias not assessed.

S31 | Sio & Lortie-Forgues, The impact of creativity training on creative performance
2024; Psychological Bulletin 150(5). Meta-analysis abstract. Indexed PubMed abstract; direct extraction incomplete. Broad creativity training, 169 studies, publication-bias caution. Not an improv-specific effect estimate; full paper not inspected.

S32 | Kang & Lee, Theatrical Language Processing
2025; arXiv v2, 15 May. Exploratory primary research. Abstract and paper text excerpts inspected. Fourteen participants; AI-generated material and interpretive freedom. Small task-specific study, not general efficacy or safety proof.

25 Source ledger | S33-S42

Checked 23 October 2026. Linked titles lead to the exact source. Access qualifications and scope limits remain part of the reference.

S33 | Mathewson & Mirowski, Improvised Comedy as a Turing Test
2017; arXiv v2. Performance research account. Full article inspected. Thirty shows; explicitly anecdotal observations and human support. No human-equivalence proof or recommendation to deceive audiences.

S34 | Jacob & Magerko, Empirically Evaluating Creative Arc Negotiation for Improvisational Decision-making
2021; ACM Creativity & Cognition. Primary research. Article text inspected. Specific CARNIVAL Props-game comparison with random selection. Selected judgments do not establish general dialogue performance.

S35 | Cho & May, Grounding Conversations with Improvised Dialogues
2020; ACL. Primary computational research. Primary paper record and research account inspected. Yes-and dialogue and grounding in dialogue systems. Not evidence for personal development, clinical benefit or safety.

S36 | Mirowski et al., A Robot Walks into a Bar
2024; ACM FAccT author record. Qualitative primary research abstract. Author record/abstract inspected; full methods not audited. Twenty professional comedians and situated workflow concerns. Not a timeless judgment of all AI comedy tools.

S37 | GDC Vault, Comedy Games: An Underexplored Genre
Session page; date not relied on. Practitioner presentation description. Official description inspected; full talk not watched. Humor in game mechanics and expectations. No detailed presentation claims inferred from the title alone.

S38 | GDC Vault, Building Games Around Humor: Lessons
Session page; date not relied on. Practitioner presentation description. Official description inspected; full talk not watched. Grace Bruxner's framing of dialogue and genre subversion. Not a validated design recipe.

S39 | U.S. Copyright Office, More Information on Fair Use
Current guidance page. Official U.S. general guidance. Official page inspected. Multi-factor, circumstance-specific analysis. Not a legal determination, worldwide rule or clearance for any particular work.

S40 | Victoria and Albert Museum, The Story of Pantomime
Institutional historical article. Historical reference. Article excerpt/indexed text inspected. Historical transformation and relation to commedia. No exact founding-date dispute or entire tradition is resolved.

S41 | Attardo & Pickering, Timing in the performance of jokes
2011; DOI 10.1515/HUMR.2011.015. Located primary study; findings not used. Publisher 405; author PDF timed out. Bibliographic lead only. Full analysis unverified; this reference makes no universal pause or pitch claim from it.

S42 | Red Thread, What Is Playback Theater?
Practitioner description; undated. Practitioner explanation. Page inspected. Volunteered personal stories enacted by performers. Paired with S18 for the separate ethics and values discussion.

Next reading: use S01 for theory, S06-S07 for classroom craft, S11 for a concrete participation boundary, S21-S22 for accessible media planning, and S29-S36 for carefully bounded research. This is a selective reference, not a systematic review.